Leadership Tool: The Power of Everyday Reflection

Self-reflection is the secret weapon of effective leadership. While most leaders focus on setting goals, managing teams, and achieving results, the ability to step back and critically assess one's own actions is often overlooked. Yet, it's in these moments of reflection that the most profound growth occurs. As Bailey and Rehman (2022) point out in their Harvard Business review article, *Power of Self-Reflection*, “Research shows the habit of reflection can separate extraordinary professionals from mediocre ones. We would go so far as to argue that it’s the foundation that all other soft skills grow from.” Whether facing the shock of an unexpected outcome or navigating the frustration of a setback, leaders who take the time to reflect on their experiences are able to turn those moments into valuable learning opportunities. By asking themselves the right questions—what happened, why it mattered, and what they can do differently—they unlock insights that shape their future success.

At its core, self-reflection is about cultivating self-awareness. Leaders who regularly reflect on their behavior and decisions gain a clearer understanding of their strengths and weaknesses. This honest evaluation helps them uncover blind spots, recognize patterns, and identify areas where they need to improve. A leader who can admit to mistakes and learn from them is far more effective than one who ignores or denies them. As Borton’s Reflective Model suggests, asking “What? So What? Now What?” allows leaders to critically analyze their performance and extract meaningful lessons that enhance their leadership.

Beyond personal growth, self-reflection is also essential for building stronger teams and organizations. When leaders reflect on how their actions impact others, they become more empathetic and attuned to the needs of their team members. This heightened awareness enables them to create a more supportive and motivating work environment. Leaders who understand the power of reflection also inspire their teams to do the same, fostering a culture of continuous learning and development that drives collective success.

Moreover, self-reflection sharpens decision-making and problem-solving abilities. When leaders take time to pause and reflect, they gain a broader perspective on challenges and opportunities. Instead of reacting impulsively to problems, they are able to step back, consider multiple viewpoints, and make more thoughtful and strategic decisions. Reflection provides the mental space needed to connect the dots between past experiences and future goals, aligning leadership actions with the broader mission of the organization.

Finally, self-reflection turns failure into a catalyst for success. Leaders who reflect on their mistakes don't see failure as the end of the road, but as a critical step toward improvement. By analyzing what went wrong and why, they can adjust their approach and avoid making the same mistakes again. Whether dealing with the frustration of a delayed project or the surprise of an unexpected challenge, reflective leaders use these experiences to refine their leadership style, adapt to changing circumstances, and ultimately become more resilient and effective in the long run.

An Easy Way to Reflect

Enter **Borton's Reflective Model**, a simple yet powerful tool designed to help you reflect on your experiences and grow from them. Developed by Terry Borton in 1970, this model revolves around three straightforward questions: **What? So What? Now What?** These three little questions have big potential to transform your leadership approach by turning everyday events into valuable learning opportunities.

Here's how to use Borton's Reflective Model in your daily leadership practice—and why it's worth your time.

1. "What?" – Start with the Facts

Think of this stage as capturing a snapshot of your day. "What happened?" That's the question you begin with. This stage is all about laying out the details of a situation you faced, without diving into your thoughts or feelings about it (yet).

For example, you might reflect on a team meeting that didn't go as planned. In this stage, you would simply describe the events: Who was there? What was discussed? What actions were taken? What were the outcomes?

This is crucial for grounding your reflection in reality. By thoroughly recounting the event, you're setting yourself up to identify key

Quick Pro Tip

TO EFFECTIVELY BREAK DOWN AN EXPERIENCE, LEADERS SHOULD APPROACH IT SYSTEMATICALLY. BEGIN BY RECALLING THE SPECIFIC DETAILS OF THE EXPERIENCE, INCLUDING THE SEQUENCE OF EVENTS, THE PEOPLE INVOLVED, AND THE CONTEXT IN WHICH THE EXPERIENCE TOOK PLACE.

BREAKING DOWN THE EXPERIENCE INTO ITS CORE COMPONENTS ALLOWS LEADERS TO SEPARATE IT INTO MANAGEABLE PARTS, MAKING IT EASIER TO ANALYZE AND UNDERSTAND. THIS PROCESS ENABLES LEADERS TO FOCUS ON SPECIFIC EVENTS AND THEIR REACTIONS TO THEM, HELPING TO IDENTIFY PATTERNS OR RECURRING THEMES THAT MAY NOT HAVE BEEN EVIDENT DURING THE EXPERIENCE ITSELF. THIS LEVEL OF DETAIL IS ESSENTIAL FOR UNCOVERING THE FACTORS THAT INFLUENCED THE OUTCOME AND FOR DEVELOPING INSIGHTS THAT CAN INFORM FUTURE BEHAVIOR AND DECISION-MAKING.

takeaways and avoid overlooking anything important. The "What?" stage builds the foundation for the deeper reflection that comes next.

2. "So What?" – Dig into the Meaning

Now we get to the heart of the reflection process: **So What?** Here, you're moving beyond the facts and starting to think about the significance of what happened. It's time to ask yourself some questions:

- *What did I learn from this experience?*
- *How did it make me feel?*
- *What strengths or weaknesses did it highlight?*

For example, in that poorly run meeting, you might realize that while your team was aligned on tasks, there was a disconnect in communication styles. Perhaps the meeting revealed that you need to foster more open dialogue or encourage quieter team members to speak up.

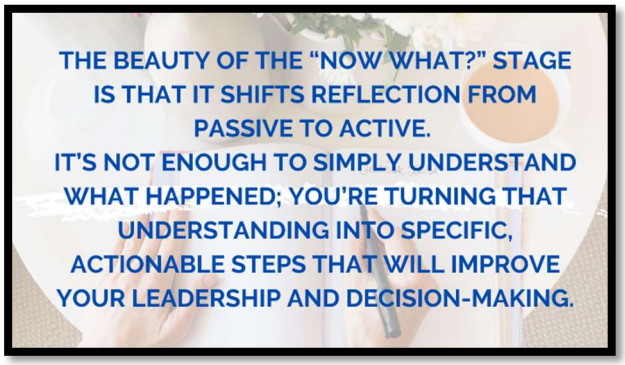
This stage is where insights are born. You're looking for the meaning behind the event—why it matters and how it impacts your leadership. It's not about blaming yourself or others but recognizing patterns, strengths, and areas for improvement.

3. "Now What?" – Turn Insights into Action

The final and most crucial step in the process: **Now What?** This is where reflection leads to action. After analyzing the significance of the event, it's time to ask yourself:

- *What will I do differently in the future?*
- *What strategies or goals can I set to improve?*
- *How can I apply what I've learned to be a more effective leader?*

For instance, after reflecting on the team meeting, you might decide to implement a strategy to ensure everyone's voice is heard in future discussions. Maybe you'll start by setting a goal to actively invite input from quieter team members or design a new meeting format that encourages more engagement.



How Borton's Model Can Transform Your Leadership

The simplicity of Borton's Reflective Model is its strength. It's quick and easy to integrate into your day, yet it offers profound opportunities for growth. Here's why it works:

- ***Accessibility*:** Whether you're a new manager or an experienced executive, Borton's three-question framework is easy to follow. You don't need to set aside hours to reflect—just a few minutes at the end of each day can provide valuable insights.

- ***Continuous Improvement*:** By consistently asking "What? So What? Now What?", you're fostering a culture of continuous learning in yourself. You're not just reacting to problems as they arise; you're proactively learning from every situation to be better in the future.
- ***Personal and Professional Growth*:** This model doesn't just help you grow as a leader; it helps you understand yourself better, enhancing both your professional and personal life. When you reflect on how experiences make you feel, you're more likely to lead with empathy, self-awareness, and resilience.

Real-World Application: How Leaders Can Reflect Every Day

So how can you, as a leader, bring this model into your daily routine? Here's a practical approach:

- ***End-of-Day Reflection*:** Spend 5-10 minutes at the end of your day asking yourself the three questions. Choose one key event or situation that stood out, whether it was a meeting, a decision you made, or an interaction with a team member.
- ***Journaling*:** If you prefer, keep a journal where you write out your answers to "What? So What? Now What?" Writing helps clarify thoughts, and over time, you'll have a record of your growth as a leader.
- ***Team Debriefs*:** Encourage your team to use this model after major projects or meetings. Not only will this help them grow, but it will also foster a culture of reflection and learning within your organization.

Reflection for the Win

Leadership is a journey, not a destination. And like any journey, the more you reflect on your experiences, the better equipped you are to navigate the road ahead. Borton's Reflective Model is a simple yet effective tool to ensure that you're not just moving forward, but growing with every step.

So, take a moment today and ask yourself: What? So What? Now What? You might be surprised at what you learn—and how it will shape your leadership tomorrow.